Yichao Jin, Ph.D.

School of Economic, Political and Policy Sciences
The University of Texas at Dallas, Richardson, TX 75080

https://yichao2022.github.io | Yichao.Jin@UTDallas.edu | +1 (682) 266-4185

Specialization: Behavioral AI / Health Economics / Behavioral Economics / Discrete Choice Experiments

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Education

University of Texas at Dallas May 2026
Ph.D. in Public Policy and Political Economy

- Successfully Defended: April 14, 2026
- Dissertation: "Intertemporal Choice in Vaccination Timing: Evidence from a Discrete Choice Experiment in Wuhan"
- Committee: Dohyeong Kim (Chair), Richard Scotch, Soyoung Kwon, Khai Chiong.
- Distinction: Dean of Graduate Education Dissertation Research Award (2025).

University of Texas at Dallas May 2026
M.S. in Social Data Analytics and Research

University of Queensland 2019
Master of Development Economics

University of California, Riverside 2017
B.A. in Economics

Research Fields

Primary: Health Economics, Applied Econometrics, Behavioral Economics, Behavioral AI
Secondary: Quantitative Methods, Policy Evaluation, Technology Governance (AI in Health)

Working Papers

"Waiting Time as a Behavioral Barrier to Vaccination Uptake: Nonlinear Heterogeneity by Institutional Trust"
Job Market Paper — **Link to Full Draft**

- Developed a structural Discrete Choice Experiment (DCE) framework to analyze the interaction between temporal barriers and institutional trust in vaccination behavior.
- Identified nonlinear heterogeneity in waiting time sensitivity, providing a behavioral explanation for vaccine hesitancy.

"Empirical-Frontier Regularization for LLM Synthetic Agents: A Behavioral Digital Twin Framework"
Working Paper — **SSRN Link**. Submitted to AI and Economics (AIE) Summer Conference 2026.

- Developed a 3-stage framework integrating DCE data and Structural Causal Modeling (SCM) to align generative agents with empirical choice frontiers, achieving a 93.8% reduction in frontier-deviation MSE.

“Ideological Contamination in Policy Simulation: Separating Political Bias from Model Capabilities in Predicting Administrative Burden Effects”
Working Paper

- Investigates the disentanglement of inherent LLM ideological priors from structural predictive capabilities. Proposes a bias-correction methodology within the BDT framework to enhance the fidelity of administrative burden simulations.

“The Ghost in the Machine: Algorithmic Rationality vs. Social Legitimacy in AI-Driven Public Health Governance”
Working Paper

- Analyzes the theoretical tension between automated efficiency and institutional trust using the AGIL framework and Rational Choice models.

“The Price of Waiting: Evidence on Cash–Time Trade-Offs in Vaccination Time Discount”
Manuscript in Preparation (Expected submission: August 2026) — Targeting *Social Science & Medicine*.

Research Experience & Affiliations

Doctoral Researcher, Spatial Health AI Research Partnership (SHARP), UT Dallas

- Leading interdisciplinary research on the intersection of artificial intelligence, geospatial analytics, and health policy.
- Managing large-scale datasets and developing computational simulations (R, Python) to evaluate pandemic preparedness.

Graduate Researcher, Behavioral Health Economics Laboratory, UT Dallas

- Conducted high-salience behavioral experiments (N=1,027) analyzing risk-weighted health decisions and institutional trust.

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, School of Economic, Political and Policy Sciences, UT Dallas

- **Quantitative Methods for Policy Analysis (Graduate)**: Led Econometrics labs; specialized in R programming, regression analysis, and causal inference.
- **Health Economics & Public Policy (Undergraduate)**: Developed case studies on health market failures and administrative challenges.
- **Public Policy Analysis (Undergraduate)**: Mentored students in drafting evidence-based policy memos.

Conference Presentations

- **AI and Economics (AIE) Summer Conference 2026**: Empirical-Frontier Regularization for LLM Synthetic Agents.
- **APPAM Fall Research Conference 2025** (Seattle, WA): Estimating Time Discount Rate for Vaccination.
- **UT Dallas Graduate Research Symposium 2025**: Modeling Vaccination Decisions with Hyperbolic Discounting.

Honors & Awards

- **2025** Dean of Graduate Education Dissertation Research Award, UT Dallas
- **2025** Betty & Gifford Johnson Graduate Travel Award, UT Dallas
- **2016** Omicron Delta Epsilon, International Honor Society for Economics

Technical Skills & Certifications

Econometrics: Mixed Logit (MXL), Latent Class Models (LCM), SEIR Modeling, Causal Inference.
Software: Stata (Advanced), R, Python, MATLAB, LaTeX, SQL, GIS.
Certifications: Stanford Artificial Intelligence Graduate Certificate; CITI Human Subjects Protection.

REFERENCES

Dohyeong Kim (Chair)
University of Texas at Dallas
Senior Associate Dean of Graduate Education
Robert E. Holmes Jr. Professor of Public Policy, GIS & Social Data Analytics
Team Lead, SHARP
dohyeong.kim@utdallas.edu

Soyoung Kwon
Associate Professor of Sociology and Public Health
Editorial Board, *Society and Mental Health*
University of Texas at Dallas
soyoung.kwon@utdallas.edu

Richard Scotch
Professor Emeritus of Sociology, Public Health, and Public Policy
University of Texas at Dallas
richard.scotch@utdallas.edu

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